

Generative AI is a type of artificial intelligence that creates new content – audio, video, image, text – in response to a user’s prompts. Its most common current uses are reducing the time and cost required for a task, cutting the financial burden of outsourcing. This means that cost cutting measures limit the use of hiring “real” talent, which can reflect poorly on the final product, but also that independent groups with limited resources can now approach their work in new ways.

This dynamic is exactly why the demo version of the video game “*Roottrees Are Dead*” is so inspiring to me. In this game the player is tasked with plotting out the Roottrees’ extended family tree in order to determine who has a claim to their inheritance. This requires the player to reference in-game search engines, newspaper clippings, family photos, etc. to find pictures of each family member, along with their name and employment details. Since this game was originally produced during a game jam with a limited timeframe, creator Jeremy Johnston used Midjourney to generate all of the visual assets.

Since generative AI was able to reduce the time and labour for the largely visual game, Johnston was able to quickly and effectively flesh out the game mechanics, and freely host his game on *itch.io*. With the popularity that it gained there, he partnered with developer Robin Ward and artist Henning Ludvigsen to rerelease a commercial version of the game on Steam.

I am inspired by Johnston’s ability to create a unique game that I greatly enjoyed, given his limited resources. Only because of his ability to generate a prototype using Midjourney was he able to further invest in his independent project. As he accumulated resources and popularity, he replaced those assets with improved character likeness and consistency and added features that made the final product distinct in its mechanics and effective in its storytelling.